



Cecile

Cecile - A Celebration

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Dedicated To

Cecile Trijssenaar - Story Teller, Anthropologist, Film Maker, Journalist, Tiger Mother, Adoption Advocate, Defender of Equality & Inclusion, Bach Flower & Wellbeing therapist...

Dear Sasha,

Cecile, your wonderful Mother, championed storytelling and books and encouraged us to share our stories. She also said that we all need to create and belong to tribes to support and lift us up. To share the highs and lows of life. By co-founding RUKA, Cecile helped create a wonderful tribe. A tribe of parents and a tribe of children/young adults who continue to support one another.

This book is given to you with love to highlight one of the most important chapters of Cecile's story – the one when she became a mother to you. However, the story doesn't stop here. It lives on in you and in all of us in RUKA who can share with you our stories of Cecile, whose energy, grit, tenacity and desire to bring together a tribe to support the parents and the children was a great success. We are your tribe now Sasha and will be there to help you, when needed, and to help you navigate the next chapters of your life.

With all our love!

Cecile





Dear Cecile

When I think of you, I see you laughing- I see your beautiful, naughty, contagious laughter, and your twinkling eyes.

And I smile. Oh Cecile, I miss you sweetheart. You have left us too early. There was still so much to do, so many more happy gatherings to have, memories to share, new memories to make.

And cakes to eat - how much you loved my custard cake! (the Croatian recipe from my mum). First time I made it, it was a long time ago - for one of our Russian Christmas parties in London, organised by you, Kathy and Fenella.

Those Christmas parties were lovely Cecile - we were so grateful - for what you did at the time for our Russian children's community was incredible. I think as much as it was important for the children, it was invaluable to us, the parents. Thank you darling Cecile.

And the children - they were toddlers then - all adorable, rosy-cheeked and happy. So much joy in that one room.

And the story continued...

Then, about 15 years later, the last time we shared a cake was when you came to see me, a couple of summers ago. We laughed - you still talked about 'the yellow cake'. On this occasion, I think I made brownies - it was too hot a day to be faffing about baking the more elaborate cake. But I promised to make it for you, the next time...

As our children were becoming a bit older, and nearly living independently, I was hoping to be seeing more of you, was hoping to have a bit more time for reminiscing/knitting, time for summer lunches and beach walks - like old ladies do.

I was hoping to be getting old and growing old alongside friends like you.. we have our own very special bond, our stories, the understanding, the shared history.

I miss you Cecile, and will carry you forever in my heart - you brave, beautiful, untamed soul.

May you rest in peace dear friend, you deserve it.

Nina Bjelica





Cecile was so helpful during our two adoptions from Russia, and so knowledgeable. She was doing such great things with her international adoption site. I always knew she would be there for us whenever we might need her.

Our best wishes,

Susie and Jonty Goodchild

I first met Cecile in the very early 2000s, through the adoption process, before either of us had adopted our wonderful children. Through the long and often frustrating journey, we spent hours on the phone, sharing our challenges with the process. Soon afterwards, Cecile had the foresight to get a group of us together to start RUKA - to keep the links with Russia going for our children. There were wonderful RUKA parties with so many people there - I think over 100 at some of the early events. Many of us who met at those early get together and parties have kept in touch over 20 years and more, and formed lasting friendships. Cecile was passionate about what she believed in, and she had the courage to fight for it. She was taken far too soon, and I will miss her laughter, her generosity, her drive and determination, and her free untamed spirit.

Fenella

Early Days





Cecile Trijssenaar - Story Teller, Anthropologist, Film Maker, Journalist, Tiger Mother, Adoption Advocate, Defender of Equality & Inclusion, Bach Flower & Wellbeing therapist...

I met Cecile more than twenty years ago at her home in Chiswick. She was hosting an open house for the preadoption community. Her enthusiastic desire to adopt from Russia was inspiring and I was in awe of her intention to navigate the Russian adoption process herself. I later learned that she was spending a great deal of time in St Petersburg, working tirelessly to make Sasha's adoption possible.

We met up with Cecile and Sasha at the Easter and Christmas RUKA parties while the children were small. Cecile had boundless energy and was often at the centre of activity.

In her work as an adoption facilitator Cecile navigated complex adoption processes to benefit other children and families. She was passionate, determined, and undaunted by the complexity of the process.

Cecile was a Tiger Mother to Sasha, who she so clearly adored. She despaired at a flawed education system and battled with authorities. She highlighted injustice, keenly sensing hidden agendas that masked bigotry. Despite sometimes being a lone voice, she determinedly stood her ground.

I became closer to Cecile when Cecile and Sasha were living in Bournemouth and after reconnecting at RUKA meet ups. I remember staying up until 3 am chatting with Cecile after a day at Go Ape in the Forest of Dean. We later spent days on the beach in Dorset, creating memories I treasure. Cecile was wonderfully supportive to me and to Kit during challenging times. She was interested, caring and forthright.

A warrior when she needed to be Cecile was warm, caring and nurturing. She was an authentic, wise, and generous friend.

Tricia and Kit Pearce





Our family loved your Mum and it was always wonderful catching up and spending time with you both at RUKA events.

Your Mum always had so much kindness, time and energy for us all. It was the welcome that you both showed to everyone that made RUKA such a warm and accepting community.

You were two of our favourite RUKA people. We saw so many of her qualities in you – your friendliness, kindness and welcoming personality.

Our hearts go out to you Sasha.

Louise, Julian and Julia Pearson

I remember Cecile as a strong independent woman, living by her sense of right and wrong. She built her family, relationships and businesses by herself. I love the homeliness of her house and used her wall colours to paint my entire house. She connected deeply with people and talked about real things. She felt anything was possible, challenged people, cared about people and bravely spoke her mind. She loved Sasha so much and would do anything for her.

Lucy Stuart-Lee



You truly touched my heart when we met the other day on the sands with the crashing waves. You seemed so so strong and brave but it must hurt so much inside.

Cecile was and is in our hearts, an incredible person who gave so much of herself to others. She gave Ella the special gift I mentioned which has helped her so much. She helped me by introducing me to so many lovely families through the Ruka parties, and building strong connections for us all.

I wish I had a photo to share of the first time I met you in your Chiswick home. You had (and still do) so much energy and life and I could see the love Cecile had for you always in her smiling eyes. The second photo I would have loved to share is standing under a beautiful leafy and shady tree in Holland Park. We all seemed to be fussing around our children while you were running happy and free - Cecile seemed to be a true free spirit and she clearly wanted that for you too.

I can't begin to imagine what you are going through but think I can understand something of your pain through my own lived experience. I am sure you will find the support you need but know that I am always here for you too.

Love

Lucy



Lord's Cricket Ground, May 2019

That is how we'll remember Cecile - with a smile. Sasha, your mum smiled her biggest smile when you entered her life. She smiled when, at one of the Ruka's first events, you ran out into the garden, played in the pouring rain, and rolled in the mud, full of joy. She smiled when you danced and sang. She smiled as she watched you grow. She smiled because of the deep love she had for you. That love will always be with you.

May you find comfort in the beautiful memories you shared, and may her love continue to guide and strengthen you through the days ahead.

You are in our thoughts, and we are here for you.

Stefania, Mark and Yeva

Cecile was a warm, bright funny generous creative person who cared passionately about her daughter Sasha and international adoption and was a good friend when one was needed. I remember lovely walks on the beach in Bournemouth with Sky, staying in her and Sasha's house in Bournemouth surrounded by things from all over the world, and laughing together. Having intense conversations as Sasha prepared to go off to Uni and, when I needed a friend, she reminded me about working in the Kalahari and how we all need a tribe sometimes and she offered to be part of mine.

She will be much missed, may her memory be for a blessing.

Best

Jeanette Copperman





Roxane really enjoyed the extra RUKA Christmas and Easter celebrations. We all have strong memories of the Orthodox Christmas traditions when she was tiny. And the blue grandfather frost. And of course the way Cecile kept the idea and traditions alive for the children.

My last definite in person memory is when we were meeting somewhere near Bracknell around Easter, and Roxane and Sasha were playing together on a climbing frame.

More generally I will always appreciate Cecile's commitment to our children adopted from Russia, to keeping the cultural links alive, to sharing approaches that help us address issues, to advocacy for a group of children and adolescents that have no formal 'voice'.

And of course her reminders **for us to try Rescue Remedy!**

Jacquie Sen and family

I first met Cecile in her Chiswick house shortly after she brought baby Sasha home. I was struck by her passion for inter country adoption. And I was amazed to find she adopted little Sasha independently! All by herself ! She was ace at organising . Her enthusiasm was electric. She was a very caring person and her devotion to Sasha was unprecedented. They had a special bond which grew and grew. They walked side by side through all the tribulations of adoption and motherhood. She was raising the young Sasha as a single mother. She worked so hard for Ruka, always found time. We salute you Cecile !

Much love and thanks for everything

Grazyna, Helena and Alex



Teens





My memory of Cecile is her unwavering and absolute love for Sasha. From the very first Cecile was blossoming and so happy they were a wonderful double act. Cecile was such a warm kind spiritual person I can't help but think she'll always be around Sasha. That is what I hope for that Sasha feels all the Love she gave her.

We have so many lovely memories from when she organised get togethers. Always helping others. The journey to adoption is so hard but she helped so much.

We will always remember her and Her Great love for you Sasha and May she continue to inspire and guide you.

Love Mary, Carl & Marina

Dearest Sasha,

We have watched you grow from a small child to the fabulous adult you are today. Thanks to your amazing mum, we were able to take part in so many RUKA events over the years and form a community here in the UK. The work your mum did in the beginning to forge that community means it's still going strong today, and we are so grateful to her for this. Your mum was an incredible lady and her love for you was obvious for all to see. We are part of your RUKA family and are always here for you.

Much love and deepest sympathies from the Knell family –

Simon, Kathryn, Hannah, Ivan and James xxx





Cecile, you helped build families where there were only hopes and dreams, guiding so many through the journey of international adoption with compassion, strength, and grace. Your legacy lives on in every child held, in every family you helped create including your own. Your heart touched so many lives - and your light will never fade. We were lucky to have met you and we will miss you deeply.

Orietta, Michele & Nicole

Cecile was one of the first people I met when I started the adoption process. I was feeling overwhelmed by lots of paperwork, and too much reading on the topic - too many opinions and conflicting advice.

It was like wading through stew. Then I went to a day of talks Cecile had organised in London for would be adopters.

Her knowledge, enthusiasm and kindness gave me the positive lift I needed to continue. If she could do it, then so could I!

Once my son Roman was home with me, I phoned her for advice over several years. She always gave me her time generously. She listened and where possible, pointed me in the right direction for further help.

She was undoubtedly the expert on all things Russian adoption.

Underpinning all of this, and most importantly, was her own experience of adopting Sasha, becoming a mother to Sasha, and being brilliant at it. She gave Sasha a rich and textured childhood, was her no. 1 advocate, and fought hard to get the things in place Sasha needed to thrive.

Sasha, I don't know you, but please accept my deepest condolences. Your Mum was a pioneer, strong and resilient. We all benefitted from her wisdom. That is no consolation for a life cut short so unexpectedly. As you go on through your own life, I hope that you will feel her strength and kindness in you.

Tracy Jeune x





Remembering Cecile for her championing of causes, her willingness to tackle problems head on, her role in setting up RUKA, her willingness to give help and advice, for the fun meet-ups for us and our wonderful adopted children, and her love for Sasha which shone out above everything else.

We will miss you, Cecile, but know that you have passed on to Sasha abiding strengths, qualities and also your pioneering spirit.

Jane and Stas

I would like to pass on this memory of Cecile when we meet in her home in Turnham Green about fifteen years ago.

She was already a very proud mum and an amazing advocate, warrior and champion for children from around the world. She had the ability to find a light to illuminate the darkness.

Sasha, may her love and light always guide you

Wishing you well

Tanya, John and Joe Spencer



Onward

Dear Sasha,

My first meeting with your wonderful Mother was at your house in Chiswick. Through her generosity and kindness to reach out to others, we had been invited there to meet other prospective adoptive parents and there ! standing in your living room was your Mum waving a very large photo of you ! her wonderful child. She was counting the days before she could collect you. Time moved forward and finally all the RUKA children were exactly where they needed to be. Thanks to your Mum and others we had the most wonderful gatherings and formed our very own tribe. Later your Mum became a true personal friend. A sacred friendship where the highs and lows could be shared. But above all we shared our joy, love and pride in our precious children. She lives on in you and we hear it in your voice and choices. May this help to guide you as you move forward. Lean on us and all of us when required.

Sharon and Liliana





With love from your RUKA family!